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Safeguarding qualitative data with QualiAnon

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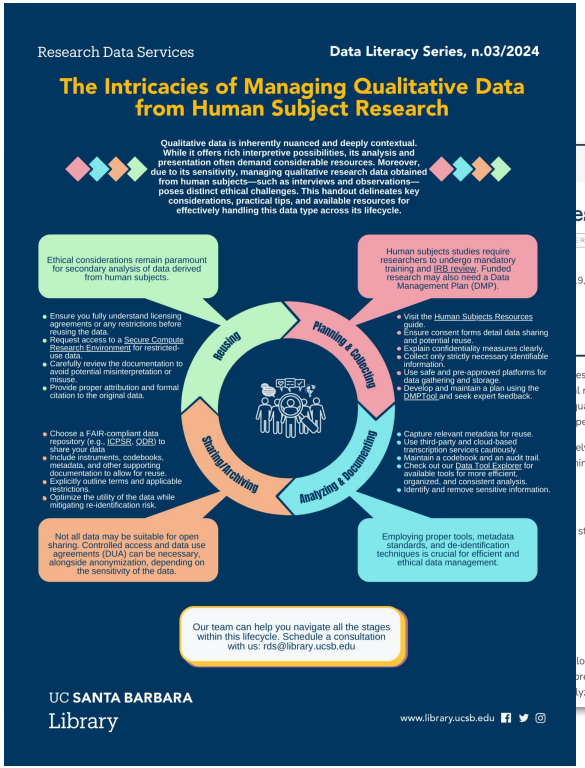
UC SANTA BARBARA

Qualitative Data

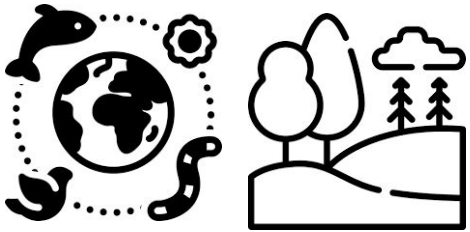
- Unstructured
- Labour intensive
- Highly contextual
- Subjective
- More prone to sensitivity
- Less “shareable”



https://perma.cc/D95L-54W8
https://ucsb-library-research-data-services.github.io/qualdata-training

Sensitive Data

Any data that could reveal the identities and harm reputations, rights, or interests of individuals or groups, as well as data that, if disclosed, may violate ethical agreements and threaten vulnerable communities, protected lands, and endangered species.



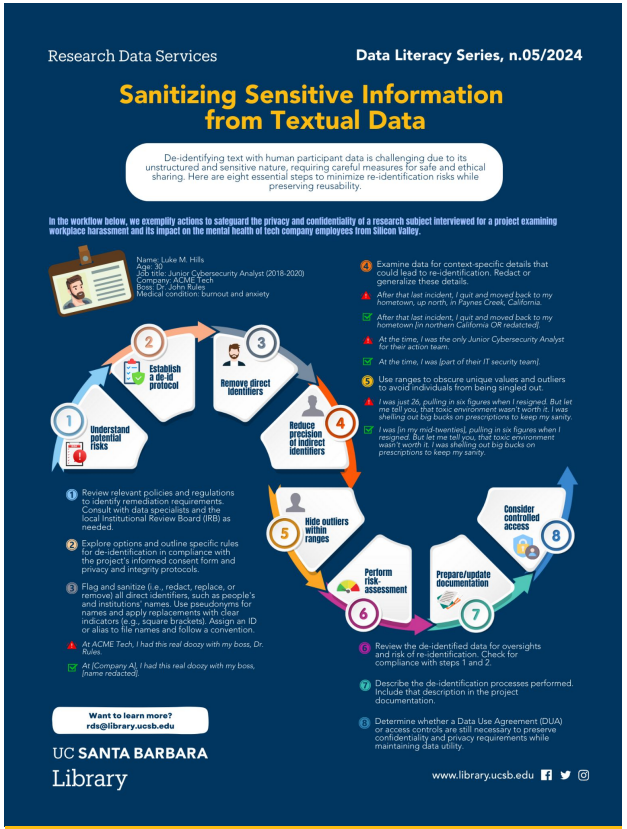
PII

detailed, personal narratives and insights including personal experiences, opinions, and emotions

Is it necessary to always de-identify data obtained from human subjects?

Handling Sensitivity

1. Understand potential risks
2. Establish a de-id protocol
3. Remove direct identifiers
4. Reduce precision of indirect identifiers
5. Hide outliers within ranges
6. Perform risk-assessment
7. Prepare/update documentation
8. Consider controlled access



https://perma.cc/LM2L-K8DN

Sensitive Data Types

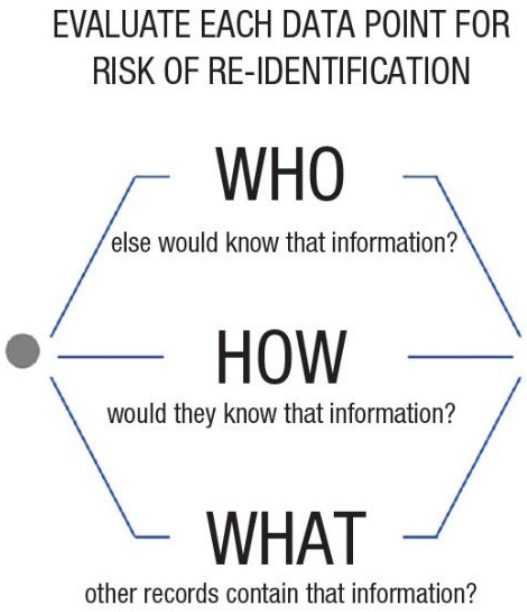
Direct Identifiers

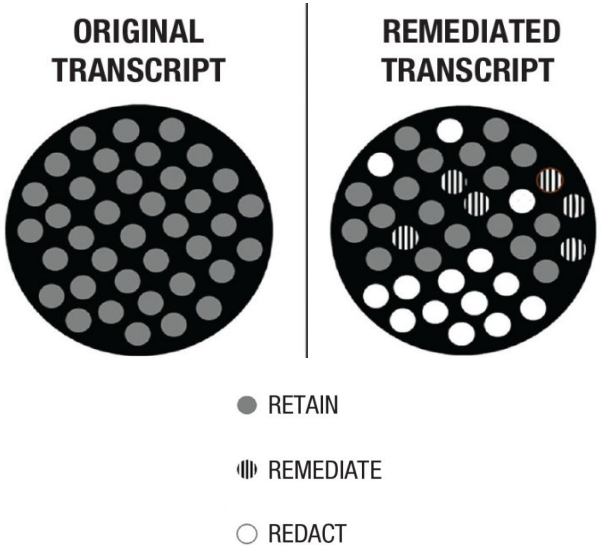
Indirect Identifiers

Dyadic Identifiers

It took me some time to realize I had to take more serious action. It started subtly back in 2022, with inappropriate comments and constant questions about my personal life, but the tipping point came Spring 2024, when, after returning from a short vacation, he sent me private welcome back message with Slack saying: "Lovely pics" (wink, wink emojis). Attached was a photo of me on the beach—something only people in my inner circle would have access to, since my profile has always been private, and I never friended him or anyone else from work. That gave me the chills! I felt extremely disrespected, invaded and really scared at the same time, so I decided to report him at work, but since nothing was done, I went to the police.

Remediating Dyadic Data





Campbell R, et.a al. Open-Science Guidance for Qualitative Research: An Empirically Validated Approach for De-Identifying Sensitive Narrative Data. *Advances in Methods and Practices in Psychological Science*. 2023;6(4). doi:10.1177/25152459231205832

Remediating Sensitivity

Category

Replacement pseudonyms

Indirect

Direct

My father, [Michael Rosenzweig], was Jewish and my mother, [Maria Kelly], was Irish Catholic. My mother went to [a girls high school] in South Philadelphia. My father went to [a co-ed high school in South Philadelphia], and then went to Penn on a [sports] scholarship. [description of his role on the team]. He thought he may have been one of the first Jews to play in the Ivy League.

Aggregate noun

Broad descriptive summary

Indirect

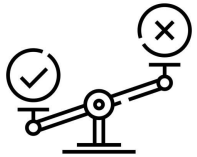
Dyadic

- Set clear rules from the outset, especially in team settings, to ensure consistency
- Use brackets to mark changes, modifications, or deletions for transparency
- Consider uploading data into analysis/viz software after de-identification is completed
- Store an unchanged file in a secure, controlled location for the retention period

Myers CA, Long SE, Polasek FO. Protecting participant privacy while maintaining content and context: Challenges in qualitative data De-identification and sharing. ProcAssoc Inf Sci Technol. 2020;57:e415. https://doi.org/10.1002/pra2.415

Tools to Support Data De-id

- NLM Scrubber
- CliniDeID
- Apache OpenNLP
- MIST (MITRE Identity Scrubber Toolkit)
- ARX Data Anonymization Tool
- QualiAnon



Comparison Table:
https://shorturl.at/wWVyn

Qualiservice
data sharing

- University of Bremen's Center for Qualitative Social Science Research Data
- Semi-automatic "flexible anonymization"
- Java-based, open Source and cross-platform
- Plug & play (no coding required)
- Runs locally

Let's explore it together!

https://github.com/pangaea-data-publisher/qualianon